

“Lead, Kindly Light”

Text: John Henry Newman, 1833

Meter: 8.8.8.8

Suggested Tune: ALBERTA

1. Lead, kindly light, amid th’ encircling
gloom; lead Thou me on!
The night is dark, and I am far from home;
lead Thou me on!
Keep firm my feet; I do not ask to see
the distant scene, one step enough for me.
2. I was not ever thus, nor prayed that Thou
shouldst lead me on.
I loved to choose and see my path, but now,
lead Thou me on!
I loved the garish day, and spite of fears,
pride ruled my will; remember not past
years.
3. So long Thy pow’r has blest me, sure it
still will lead me on,
o’er moor and fen, o’er crag and torrent, till
the night is gone,
and with the morn those angel faces smile,
which I have loved long since, and lost
awhile.

Reflection (Feast of St. John Henry Newman):

This hymn was written by John Henry Newman. It tells a story of trusting in God through uncertainty. Although written years before his conversion to Catholicism, it could be read as an analogy for Newman’s own conversion from the Church of England to the “home” that he found in the Catholic Church.

Verse 1 begins in the present. The author asks God, the “kindly light,” to lead him through the gloomy darkness of night.

Twice, he repeats the petition “lead Thou me on,” emphasizing his great trust in God’s guidance. Although his “home” is far away, the author doesn’t need to see it to know that he is safe under God’s protecting help. Rather, with confidence, he continues forward knowing that God is keeping him safe one step at a time. The language of this text echoes Psalm 119:105; the author walks his path with nothing but God to help him.

Whereas verse 1 described the author’s present confidence in God, verse 2 reflects on his former rebelliousness from Him. He confesses that never before did he have such confidence in God – never did he pray for God’s guidance. Instead, he loved choosing his own path, a path which was filled with worldly distractions and prideful self-reliance. This is in sharp contrast to the present, where he lets God choose his path and he doesn’t even ask to see it.

Finally, verse 3 looks into the future. Since God has, up to this point, kept him safe through many obstacles, the author is certain that God will finally lead him to the “home” that he referred to at the beginning. Once the dark night is over, the new day will begin and he will see the angels smiling to greet him. This home, for which he longs to be led, is heaven.